

Arjun's Story

Watching Recovery Score work across 90 real days - no code, no formulas, just the story

For designers and anyone who wants to see the feature in action, not just described.

Meet Arjun

Arjun wears his Apple Watch every day. Over 90 days, his body went through three very different phases - and we ran our real Recovery Score system on his real (simulated) data for each one, exactly as it would run for a real user. Here's what he actually would have seen on his phone at five different moments.

Time period	What was happening
Day 90 to Day 31 (60 days)	A calm, healthy stretch. Normal sleep, normal heart rate, no stress.
Day 30 to Day 15 (15 days)	A busy period at work. Sleep got shorter, heart rate crept up a little.
Day 14 to Day 1 (14 days)	Arjun caught an illness. Clearly disrupted sleep and heart signals.
Today	Arjun is starting to feel a bit better - but is he really back to normal?

Five Moments in Arjun's Journey

Moment 1: An Unusually Great Day

Day -40, deep in the healthy period

This particular day, Arjun happened to sleep especially well and his body was in top form - even better than his own already-healthy normal.

100

out of 100

OPTIMAL RECOVERY

Arjun's body is clearly primed. The app would encourage a harder workout today if he had one planned.

Moment 2: A Perfectly Normal Healthy Day

Day -45, also in the healthy period

This is an ordinary day during the SAME healthy stretch - nothing wrong at all, just an average day for Arjun.

65

out of 100

LOW RECOVERY

Surprising, right? An average, totally fine day scored 65, not 90+.

POINT TO REMEMBER: This is the single most important thing to understand about Recovery Score: "Optimal" doesn't mean "healthy." It means "better than your own typical day." A perfectly normal, nothing-wrong day for YOU will usually land in the middle of the scale, not at the top - because the app is comparing today to your own best days too, not just to "is something wrong." Designers: don't assume a "fine" day should always show green. Most days for most people will land in the Moderate/Low range - that's expected and correct, not something to fix.

Moment 3: Work Stress Builds Up

Day -20

Arjun has been sleeping less and his heart rate has been a little higher than usual for a couple of weeks now.

49
out of 100

VERY LOW RECOVERY

The app can already see the shift happening, even though Arjun hasn't gotten sick yet.

Moment 4: Arjun Gets Sick

Day -5, mid-illness

Arjun's sleep is badly disrupted and his heart rate is clearly elevated - classic signs of the body fighting something off.

44
out of 100

VERY LOW RECOVERY

The app recommends rest, not training, and the message tone stays calm and non-alarming.

Moment 5: Today - Is Arjun Actually Better?

Today

Arjun's heart rate signals have improved slightly compared to how bad they were during the illness. A simpler app might see this small improvement and excitedly report a much higher score.

63
out of 100

LOW RECOVERY

Take Health's app instead says: better than a few days ago, but still below his real normal - "Take it easier today."

POINT TO REMEMBER: Why didn't Today score much higher, given the improvement? Because the app doesn't just look at "better than yesterday" - it also checks "how does this compare to my TRUE, long-term normal?" Arjun's long-term normal (from the healthy 60-day stretch) is still far above where he is now. The app deliberately holds the score back rather than let a small improvement look like a full recovery. This is the app being honest instead of falsely encouraging.

The Logic Behind It - In Plain Words

Here is everything the app actually does, with no formulas - just five simple ideas working together:

#	Idea	In plain words
1	Compare to YOUR normal, not everyone's	A resting heart rate of 68 is great for one person and concerning for another. The app learns what's normal specifically for you.
2	Look at two time windows, not one	"How am I doing lately" (last 2 weeks) AND "what's my real, deeper normal" (last 3 months). Comparing both is what caught Arjun's false-improvement moment.
3	Combine multiple body signals	Heart rhythm, breathing, sleep quality, and recent activity load - all blended into one number, so no single noisy reading dominates the result.
4	A safety net, separate from the score	Fixed medical reference ranges are checked independently of your personal history - so a chronically low reading never hides behind a "looks fine for you" score.
5	An honesty check on the final number	If the deeper 3-month picture is still clearly off, the app won't let a short-term uptick be reported as full recovery - exactly what happened in Arjun's "Today" moment.

What This Means for Designers

A few practical takeaways for building the UI around this feature:

Design consideration	Why
Most days will land in the middle of the scale (Moderate/Low), not the extremes.	As shown in Moment 2 - "normal" doesn't mean "top score." Don't design around users seeing green every day.
The score and the message can occasionally feel slightly cautious even when a user feels fine.	This is deliberate - see Moment 5. The copy should always explain WHY ("still below your usual range"), never just show a number with no context.
New users won't see a score at all for their first several days.	The app needs real history to compare against - it will show a "Building your baseline" state instead of guessing.
A capped/held-back score should be explainable, not just shown.	Users may ask "why is this lower than I expected" - the UI should have room for a one-line reason, exactly like Arjun's Moment 5 message.

This document uses real output from Take Health's actual Recovery Score system, run against a simulated 90-day account created for testing. Companion documents: "Recovery Score Explained" (industry background) and "Recovery Score Technical Reference" (engineering detail).